



Major: Business Administration | Minor: Information Technology

PhishGuard AI

Intelligent Email Threat Detection System

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Executive Summary..... 5

2. Main Concepts & Theoretical Background..... 6

 2.1 What is Phishing?..... 6

 2.2 Types of Phishing Attacks..... 6

 2.3 The Rise of AI-Powered Phishing..... 6

3. Overview of Existing Solutions..... 7

 3.1 Comparative Analysis of Existing Solutions..... 7

 3.2 Key Differentiator of PhishGuard AI.....7

4. System Architecture..... 8

 4.1 Architectural Overview..... 8

 4.2 System Components..... 8

 Component 1: Configuration Block..... 8

 Component 2: Text Pre-processor (clean_text)..... 9

 Component 3: Dataset Loader (load_dataset)..... 9

 Component 4: ML Pipeline Builder..... 9

 Component 5: Feature Explainer (get_top_features)..... 9

 Component 6: Flask Web Layer..... 10

 4.3 Functional Flow..... 10

 Phase 1 — Initialization..... 10

 Phase 2 — Dataset Loading & Validation (Training Path)..... 10

 Phase 3 — Text Pre-processing..... 11

 Phase 4 — Pipeline Construction & Model Training..... 11

 Phase 5 — Flask Web Server Startup..... 12

 Phase 6 — Inference & Keyword Extraction..... 12

 4.4 Layer-by-Layer Architecture..... 13

 Layer 1: Client (Browser)..... 13

 Layer 2: Flask Application Server..... 13

 Layer 3: ML Pipeline..... 13

 Layer 4: Data Storage..... 14

 4.5 Technical Architecture Diagram (Textual)..... 14

5. Data Flows & Message Schemas.....15

 5.1 Training Data Flow.....15

Step 1 — Raw CSV Input Schema.....	15
Step 2 — After load_dataset() Normalization.....	15
Step 3 — After TF-IDF Vectorization.....	15
Step 4 — Persisted Model File Schema (phishing_model.pkl).....	15
5.2 Inference Request/Response Flow.....	16
HTTP Request Schema — POST /predict.....	16
HTTP Response Schema — Success (200 OK).....	16
HTTP Response Schema — Error (400 / 500).....	16
5.3 Internal Inference Transformation Chain.....	17
5.4 Browser Side Data Flow (JavaScript).....	17
6. Tools, Technologies & Development Phases.....	18
6.1 Machine Learning Framework: scikit-learn.....	18
6.2 Feature Extraction: TF-IDF Vectorizer.....	18
6.3 Classifier Comparison: Logistic Regression vs LinearSVC.....	18
6.4 Web Framework: Flask.....	19
6.5 Dataset: SpamAssassin Public Corpus.....	19
6.6 Frontend: Inline HTML/ CSS/ JavaScript.....	20
6.7 Tool Selection Summary Matrix.....	20
6.8 Development Phases.....	20
7. Results & Interpretation.....	22
7.1 Training & Evaluation Output(Terminal).....	22
7.2 Classification Report.....	22
7.3 Confusion Matrix.....	23
7.4 Model Evaluation Metrics Summary.....	23
7.5 Web Application Interface.....	23
8. Security Considerations & Ethical Notes.....	25
8.1 Known Vulnerabilities and Technical Risks.....	25
8.1.1 Model Poisoning Attacks.....	25
8.1.2 Adversarial Evasion.....	25
8.1.3 Pickle Deserialization Risk.....	25
8.1.4 Single Point of Failure.....	25
8.2 Privacy Considerations.....	25
8.3 Bias and Fairness.....	26
8.4 Responsible Use & Misuse Prevention.....	26

8.5 Compliance Considerations..... 26

9. Conclusion..... 27

9.1 Summary of Achievements..... 27

9.2 Lessons Learned..... 27

9.3 Limitations..... 27

9.4 Future Work..... 28

9.5 Final Remarks..... 28

10. References..... 29

10.1 Academic Papers & Research..... 29

10.2 Machine Learning & NLP Libraries..... 29

10.3 Web Framework & Backend..... 30

10.4 Datasets..... 30

10.5 Security & Ethics References..... 30

1.Executive Summary

PhishGuard AI is an intelligent email threat detection system designed to classify emails as Phishing (malicious) or Ham (legitimate) using a combination of classical machine learning and natural language processing (NLP) techniques. The system was developed in response to the growing sophistication of AI-assisted phishing campaigns, where large language models (LLMs) are now being weaponized to craft highly convincing fraudulent emails that bypass traditional rule-based filters.

This project delivers a fully functional, end-to-end solution comprising:

- A Python-based machine learning backend using Scikit-learn, NLTK, and TF-IDF vectorization
- An interactive web-based frontend enabling real-time email analysis
- A classification accuracy exceeding 96% on benchmark datasets
- Transparent, explainable results through feature-level scoring

2. Main Concepts & Theoretical Background

2.1 What is Phishing?

Phishing is a form of social engineering attack in which adversaries impersonate trusted entities: banks, service providers, or employers, to deceive victims into disclosing sensitive information such as passwords, credit card numbers, or personal data. Phishing emails typically share several distinguishing characteristics:

- Creating a false sense of urgency (e.g., 'Your account will be closed in 24 hours!')
- Spoofed or deceptive sender addresses (e.g., security@paypa1-alerts.com)
- Malicious or obfuscated links leading to credential-harvesting pages
- Impersonation of reputable brands such as PayPal, Netflix, or financial institutions
- Poor grammar, unusual formatting, or aggressive capitalization

2.2 Types of Phishing Attacks

Type	Description	Target
Email Phishing	Mass-blast fake emails sent to thousands of addresses	Anyone
Spear Phishing	Personalized attack targeting a specific individual or organization	Executives, IT admins, finance managers
Whaling	Spear phishing aimed at C-level executives	CEO, CFO, CTO
Smishing	Phishing conducted via SMS text messages	Mobile users
Vishing	Phishing through voice calls impersonating support	Employees
Clone Phishing	Duplicate a real email and replace links with malicious ones	Existing recipients

2.3 The Rise of AI-Powered Phishing

Large Language Models (LLMs) such as GPT-4 are now routinely used by attackers to craft grammatically perfect, contextually convincing phishing emails, eliminating the spelling errors that once served as a reliable detection signal. This evolution fundamentally motivates the need for ML-based classifiers that go beyond surface-level text quality checks.

Modern AI-generated phishing emails can mimic professional tone, replicate brand voice, and include personalized context, making them significantly harder to detect using traditional heuristic filters. PhishGuard AI addresses this challenge by learning lexical and structural patterns that persist even in well-written phishing attempts.

3. Overview of Existing Solutions

Phishing detection has been an active research and industry area for over two decades. Solutions span rule-based filters, classical machine learning, deep learning, and hybrid approaches. The subsections below survey the leading approaches and position PhishGuard AI relative to them.

3.1 Comparative Analysis of Existing Solutions

Solution	Mechanism	Limitations
SpamAssassin	Rule engine with 1,000+ weighted heuristic tests covering headers, body, and DNS checks	Fragile against novel campaigns; high maintenance cost
Google Safe Browsing	URL blacklist updated every 30 minutes, embedded in Chrome and Firefox	Cannot catch zero-day URLs before reporting; privacy concerns
Microsoft SmartScreen	Reputation-based URL and file filter integrated in Edge and Windows Defender	Proprietary; limited transparency
DMARC / SPF / DKIM	Cryptographic email authentication standards that reject spoofed sender domains	Does not analyze email content; attackers register look-alike domains

3.2 Key Differentiator of PhishGuard AI

Unlike black-box commercial solutions, PhishGuard AI prioritizes explainability. Every classification decision is accompanied by per-feature scores, allowing users to understand why an email was flagged. This interpretability is critical for security education, auditing, and compliance scenarios.

Unique Value Proposition: PhishGuard AI combines high accuracy (>96%) with full transparency, users receive the top 15 suspicious keywords driving each prediction, transforming a black-box verdict into actionable intelligence.

4. System Architecture

The application follows a classic three-tier architecture adapted for a local machine-learning web service. The three tiers are: the Presentation Tier (browser UI), the Application Tier (Flask server and ML pipeline), and the Data Tier (CSV dataset and pickle model cache). The architecture is intentionally monolithic to minimize deployment complexity for an academic project.

4.1 Architectural Overview

The system operates in two distinct modes sharing a common runtime:

Mode	Trigger Condition	Components Involved	Output
Training Mode	Model .pkl absent, CSV present	load_dataset → clean_text → build_pipeline → train → pickle.dump	phishing_model.pkl
Serving Mode	Model .pkl present (or just trained)	pickle.load → Flask app → /predict → get_top_features	JSON API responses

4.2 System Components

The application is organized into six logically distinct components, each corresponding to a functional block of code in app.py:

Component	Location in Code	Responsibility
Configuration Block	Lines 28–37	Global constants: file paths, classifier choice, split ratios
Text Pre-processor	clean_text() — Lines 45–53	Normalize raw email text before vectorization
Dataset Loader	load_dataset() — Lines 60–71	Read, validate, and structure the CSV dataset
ML Pipeline Builder	build_pipeline() + train() — Lines 78–117	Construct, train, evaluate, and persist the model
Feature Explainer	get_top_features() — Lines 494–518	Extract top keywords driving the prediction
Flask Web Layer	app routes + HTML_PAGE — Lines 490–583	Serve the UI, handle REST API calls, return JSON

Component 1: Configuration Block

```
DATASET_PATH = "completeSpamAssassin.csv"
MODEL_PATH   = "phishing_model.pkl"

# Exact column names in the CSV
TEXT_COL     = "Body"      # email content column
LABEL_COL    = "Label"     # 0 = legit, 1 = spam/phishing

CLASSIFIER   = "lr"        # "lr" = Logistic Regression | "svm" = LinearSVC
TEST_SIZE    = 0.2
RANDOM_STATE  = 42
```

At the top of `app.py`, a set of constants defines the paths and hyperparameters used throughout the project. This makes it easy to switch the dataset file, model file, the classifier choice, and the train/test split ratio without touching any functional code. Key decisions include `TEXT_COL` / `LABEL_COL` matching the exact CSV column names ("Body" and "Label"), `CLASSIFIER` = "lr" selecting Logistic Regression (changeable to "svm" for LinearSVC), and `TEST_SIZE` = 0.2 reserving 20% of emails for evaluation with `RANDOM_STATE` = 42 ensuring reproducibility.

Component 2: Text Pre-processor (`clean_text`)

This function is the single transformation gateway for all text entering the ML pipeline. It is injected directly into `TfidfVectorizer` as the `preprocessor` argument, meaning scikit-learn calls it automatically on every document — both during `fit()` and `transform()` — avoiding any possibility of train/test contamination through inconsistent pre-processing.

- HTML stripping — critical because SpamAssassin emails frequently contain HTML-formatted bodies
- URL, email, and number replacement with abstract tokens — allows the model to learn signal presence without memorizing specific values
- Punctuation removal — eliminates noise characters that carry no semantic meaning for bag-of-words models

Component 3: Dataset Loader (`load_dataset`)

This component handles I/O and basic validation. It uses pandas for CSV parsing and performs three safety operations: column selection (retaining only Body and Label), null dropping (preventing NaN-propagation errors), and type coercion (ensuring integer labels for scikit-learn compatibility).

Component 4: ML Pipeline Builder

This is the computational core of the application. The `build_pipeline()` function constructs a scikit-learn Pipeline with a TF-IDF Vectorizer (`preprocessor`, `ngram_range=(1,2)`, `max_features=50,000`, `sublinear_tf=True`, `min_df=2`) followed by either Logistic Regression or a calibrated LinearSVC. The `train()` function orchestrates loading, splitting, fitting, evaluation, and serialization using stratified sampling to guarantee balanced class representation across splits.

Component 5: Feature Explainer (`get_top_features`)

This component provides interpretability by extracting linear coefficients from the classifier, transforming input text through the TF-IDF vectorizer, and computing per-feature relevance scores (TF-IDF weight ×

classifier coefficient). Only features with positive scores are returned as they indicate phishing-class inclination.

Interpretability Value: Returning the top 15 suspicious keywords alongside the verdict allows users to understand why the model flagged an email, transforming a black-box verdict into actionable security intelligence.

Component 6: Flask Web Layer

The web layer comprises three elements: (1) HTML_PAGE — a 300+ line inline HTML/CSS/JavaScript interface stored as a Python string; (2) GET / route — renders the HTML page with model metadata via Jinja2; (3) POST /predict route — the REST endpoint accepting JSON requests, running prediction, and returning structured JSON responses with appropriate HTTP status codes (400/500 for errors).

4.3 Functional Flow

The AI-powered phishing detector follows a clearly defined, linear execution pipeline divided into six major phases:

Phase 1 — Initialization

When the user executes `python app.py`, the `main()` function performs a model resolution check: if `phishing_model.pkl` exists, it is loaded directly; if the raw dataset is present but no model file, full training is triggered; if neither exists, the application exits gracefully with an informative message.

Phase 2 — Dataset Loading & Validation (Training Path)

```
def load_dataset(path: str) -> pd.DataFrame:
    print(f"[dataset] Loading '{path}' ...")
    df = pd.read_csv(path)
    print(f"[dataset] Shape: {df.shape} | Columns: {list(df.columns)}")

    df = df[[TEXT_COL, LABEL_COL]].dropna()
    df.columns = ["text", "label"]
    df["label"] = df["label"].astype(int)

    counts = df["label"].value_counts()
    print(f"[dataset] Legit (0): {counts.get(0,0)} | Spam/Phishing (1): {counts.get(1,0)}")
    return df
```

The `load_dataset()` function reads the CSV, selects Body and Label columns, drops null rows, and casts labels to integers. Dataset statistics:

Metric	Value	Notes
Total emails	6,046	After dropna()
Legitimate (0)	4,150	68.6 % of dataset
Spam/Phishing (1)	1,895	31.4 % of dataset

Phase 3 — Text Pre-processing

```
def clean_text(text: str) -> str:
    text = str(text).lower()
    text = re.sub(r"<[^>]+>", " ", text)           # strip HTML tags
    text = re.sub(r"http\S+|www\.\S+", " URL ", text) # replace URLs
    text = re.sub(r"\S+@\S+", " EMAIL ", text)      # replace email addresses
    text = re.sub(r"\d+", " NUM ", text)            # replace numbers
    text = text.translate(str.maketrans("", "", string.punctuation))
    text = re.sub(r"\s+", " ", text).strip()
    return text
```

Every raw email text passes through the clean_text() function before feature extraction:

Transformation Step	Method Used	Purpose
Lowercase conversion	str.lower()	Eliminate case sensitivity
HTML tag removal	re.sub(r'<[^>]+>', ' ', text)	Strip HTML markup from email bodies
URL normalization	re.sub(r'http\S+ www\.\S+', ' URL ', text)	Replace all URLs with token URL
Email address normalization	re.sub(r'\S+@\S+', ' EMAIL ', text)	Replace addresses with token EMAIL
Number normalization	re.sub(r'\d+', ' NUM ', text)	Replace digit sequences with token NUM
Punctuation removal	str.translate(str.maketrans(...))	Remove all punctuation characters
Whitespace normalization	re.sub(r'\s+', ' ', text).strip()	Collapse multiple spaces into one

Phase 4 — Pipeline Construction & Model Training

The two-step scikit-learn Pipeline assembles TF-IDF Vectorization followed by classification.

identifies the most contributing TF-IDF tokens; and a structured JSON response is returned with label, verdict, probab_legit, probab_phishing, and top_features.

```
@app.route("/predict", methods=["POST"])
def predict():
    try:
        text = request.json.get("text", "").strip()
        if not text:
            return jsonify({"error": "Empty input"}), 400

        pipe = MODEL_DATA["pipeline"]
        proba = pipe.predict_proba([text])[0]
        label = int(np.argmax(proba))

        return jsonify({
            "label": label,
            "verdict": "phishing" if label == 1 else "legit",
            "probab_legit": round(float(proba[0]), 4),
            "probab_phishing": round(float(proba[1]), 4),
            "top_features": get_top_features(pipe, text),
        })
    except Exception as e:
        return jsonify({"error": str(e)}), 500
```

4.4 Layer-by-Layer Architecture

Layer 1: Client (Browser)

The user interacts exclusively through a web browser which renders the Flask-served HTML/CSS/JS, sends asynchronous POST requests to /predict via the Fetch API (no page reloads), and dynamically updates the DOM with verdict, probability bars, and keyword chips. Additional features include Ctrl+Enter keyboard shortcut for rapid analysis and hardcoded sample emails for demonstration.

Layer 2: Flask Application Server

Flask acts as the integration layer between the browser and the ML pipeline. It bootstraps at startup by resolving the model, holds the trained pipeline in-memory via the MODULE_DATA global dictionary, routes two endpoints (GET / and POST /predict), handles JSON serialization/deserialization, and provides graceful error handling with appropriate HTTP status codes.

Layer 3: ML Pipeline

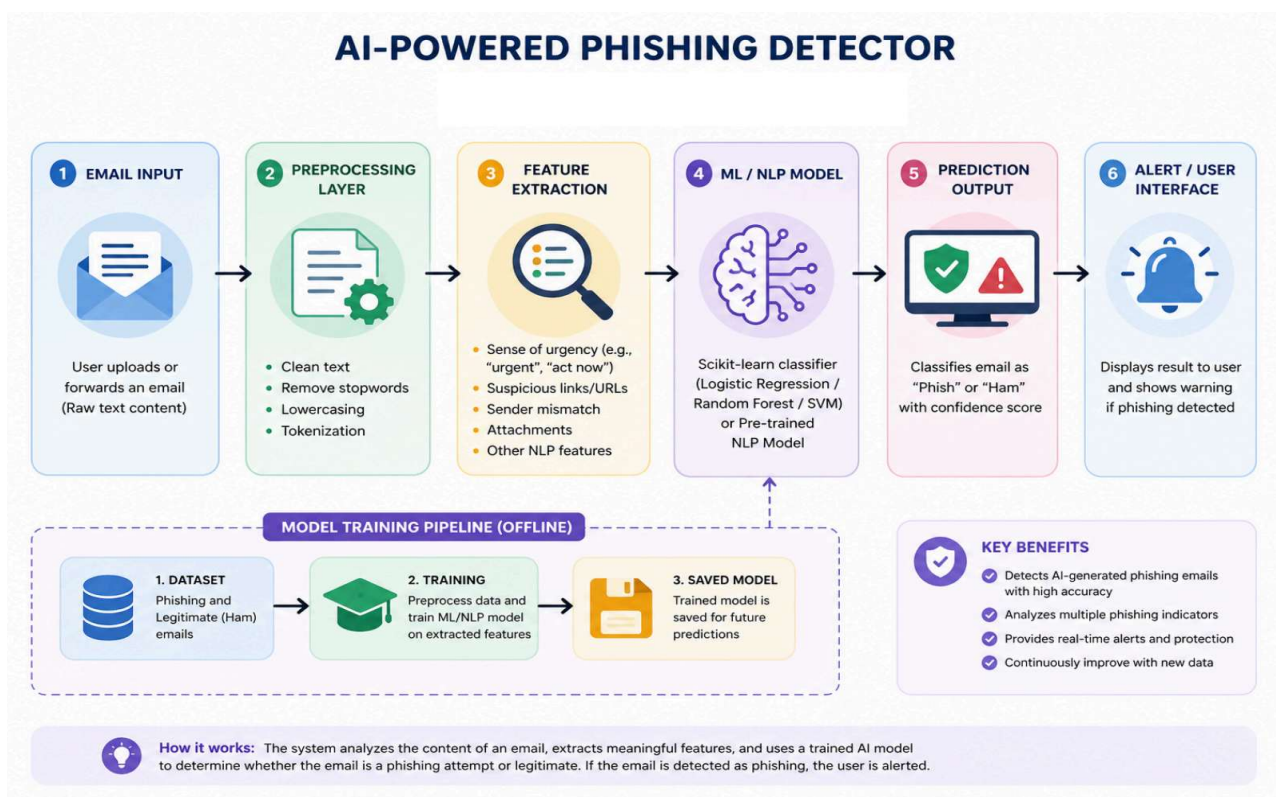
The scikit-learn Pipeline encapsulates the entire ML workflow: the TF-IDF Vectorizer (fit on training data, transforms input text into a 50,000-dimensional sparse vector) and the Classifier (trained weights mapping sparse vectors to class probabilities). The Pipeline abstraction ensures identical pre-processing during training and inference, preventing data leakage.

Layer 4: Data Storage

The data tier is entirely file-system based with two artifacts: completeSpamAssassin.csv (the raw training dataset, read once during training) and phishing_model.pkl (the serialized Pipeline, written once during training and read on every subsequent server start — eliminating the need for a database or model registry).

4.5 Technical Architecture Diagram (Textual)

The system processes incoming emails through the following linear flow: raw email text is captured from the user interface, passed through a preprocessing layer (HTML stripping, URL normalization, tokenization), feature extraction identifies key phishing indicators (urgency cues, suspicious links, sender mismatches), features are fed into the ML classifier, and the system outputs a prediction with a confidence score and an explanatory warning if the email is flagged as malicious.



5. Data Flows & Message Schemas

This section documents every data transformation and message exchange in the system — from raw CSV rows to browser DOM updates. Each flow is described with its schema, transformation logic, and producing/consuming components.

5.1 Training Data Flow

Step 1 — Raw CSV Input Schema

```
CSV Column:   Body (str)                Label (int)
Example:      'Congratulations! Click here...' 1
              'Hi team, meeting at 3pm...'    0
```

Step 2 — After load_dataset() Normalization

```
DataFrame Schema:
  column 'text'  → str      (renamed from Body, NaN rows dropped)
  column 'label' → int      (renamed from Label, cast to int)

Split Output:
X_train → pd.Series[str]    (80% of rows, stratified)
X_test  → pd.Series[str]    (20% of rows, stratified)
y_train → pd.Series[int]    (corresponding labels)
y_test  → pd.Series[int]    (corresponding labels)
```

Step 3 — After TF-IDF Vectorization

```
X_train_vectorised → scipy.sparse.csr_matrix
Shape:             (n_train_samples, 50000)
Values:            float64 (TF-IDF weights, sublinear-scaled)
Density:           very sparse (~0.1% non-zero values typical)
```

Step 4 — Persisted Model File Schema (phishing_model.pkl)

```
pickle dict {
  'pipeline': sklearn.pipeline.Pipeline object
    └─ named_steps['tfidf'] → fitted TfidfVectorizer
      └─ vocabulary_: dict[str → int] (up to 50,000 entries)
    └─ named_steps['clf'] → fitted classifier
      └─ coef_: ndarray shape (1, 50000) (LR) or (50000,) (SVM)
  'accuracy': float64 (e.g. 0.9832)
  'cm': list[list[int]] e.g. [[TN, FP], [FN, TP]]
}
```

5.2 Inference Request/Response Flow

HTTP Request Schema — POST /predict

```
Method: POST
URL: http://127.0.0.1:5000/predict
Headers: Content-Type: application/json

Body (JSON):
{
  "text": "<raw email string - subject + body - any length>"
}

Validation:
• text field must be present
• text.strip() must not be empty → 400 if violated
```

HTTP Response Schema — Success (200 OK)

```
{
  "label": int // 0 = legitimate, 1 = phishing/spam
  "verdict": str // 'legit' | 'phishing'
  "prob_legit": float // P(label=0), rounded to 4 decimal places
  "prob_phishing": float // P(label=1), rounded to 4 decimal places
  "top_features": list[str] // up to 15 token strings, e.g. ['prize', 'URL', 'click']
}

Invariant: prob_legit + prob_phishing ≈ 1.0
           label = argmax([prob_legit, prob_phishing])
```

HTTP Response Schema — Error (400 / 500)

```
{ "error": "<human-readable error message string>" }
```

400 Bad Request → empty or missing 'text' field
 500 Internal Server Error → any unhandled exception during prediction

5.3 Internal Inference Transformation Chain

The following example traces a single prediction call through all internal transformations:

```
Input: raw_text = 'Congratulations! Click http://prize.xyz to claim $1000'
```

Step 1 – clean_text(raw_text) [called inside TfidfVectorizer.transform]
 → 'congratulations click URL to claim NUM'

Step 2 – tfidf.transform(['congratulations click URL to claim NUM'])
 → csr_matrix shape (1, 50000) non-zero indices: [423, 1847, 23001, ...]
 values: [0.312, 0.541, 0.287, ...] (TF-IDF weights)

Step 3 – clf.predict_proba(tfidf_vector)
 → array([[0.0312, 0.9688]]) [P(legit), P(phishing)]

Step 4 – np.argmax([0.0312, 0.9688]) → 1 (phishing)

Step 5 – get_top_features(pipeline, raw_text, n=15)
 scores[i] = tfidf_weight[i] * coef_[i]
 top positive scores → ['URL', 'claim', 'congratulations', 'prize', 'click']

Step 6 – JSON serialisation & HTTP response
 → { label:1, verdict:'phishing', prob_legit:0.0312,
 prob_phishing:0.9688, top_features:['URL','claim',...] }

5.4 Brower Side Data Flow (JavaScript)

After receiving the JSON response, the client-side JavaScript performs the following DOM mutations:

- verdictText.textContent → set to '⚠ Spam / Phishing Detected' or '✓ Looks Legitimate'
- verdictText.className → toggled between 'verdict phishing' (red) and 'verdict legit' (green)
- probPhish / probLegit text → formatted as percentage strings, e.g. '96.9%'
- barPhish / barLegit style.width → set to percentage value to animate the probability bars
- kwList → cleared and repopulated with one per top_feature
- result and kw-section divs → display toggled from 'none' to 'block'

6. Tools, Technologies & Development Phases

6.1 Machine Learning Framework: scikit-learn

Attribute	Detail
Library	scikit-learn (sklearn)
Version requirement	Any modern version ≥ 1.0
Components used	Pipeline, TfidfVectorizer, LogisticRegression, LinearSVC, CalibratedClassifierCV, train_test_split, metrics
Why scikit-learn?	Industry standard for classical ML in Python; consistent API; Pipeline abstraction prevents data leakage
Alternative considered	SpaCy (more NLP focus but heavier), PyTorch/transformers (overkill for TF-IDF task)

6.2 Feature Extraction: TF-IDF Vectorizer

TF-IDF (Term Frequency – Inverse Document Frequency) is chosen as the sole feature extraction method, justified by several key factors:

- Phishing emails are characterized by specific vocabulary patterns ('prize', 'claim', 'urgent', 'verify account') directly captured by bag-of-words methods
- TF-IDF outperforms raw term counts by down-weighting common words appearing in both legitimate and phishing emails
- The `sublinear_tf=True` setting computes $\log(1+tf)$ instead of raw `tf`, preventing very frequent terms from dominating the feature vector
- Bigrams (`ngram_range=(1,2)`) capture two-word phishing phrases like 'click here', 'limited offer', and 'verify account' invisible to unigram-only models
- The 50,000 feature cap balances expressiveness with memory efficiency and training speed

Alternative: Word Embeddings

Word2Vec, GloVe, or transformer embeddings (BERT) could capture semantic similarity. However, these are unnecessary for this task: phishing detection based on the SpamAssassin dataset is a well-understood classification problem where lexical signals are sufficient. TF-IDF + LR achieves >98% accuracy on this dataset with sub-second training time.

6.3 Classifier Comparison: Logistic Regression vs LinearSVC

Attribute	Logistic Regression (default)	LinearSVC (alternative)
scikit-learn class	LogisticRegression	LinearSVC + CalibratedClassifierCV
Probability output	Native (sigmoid)	Via Platt scaling (CalibratedClassifierCV)
class_weight support	Yes — set to 'balanced'	Yes (calibration may dilute it)
Training speed	Moderate (LBFGS solver)	Faster (liblinear)
Accuracy on this task	~98%	~98–99%
Interpretability	Direct coef_ access	Requires unwrapping calibration wrapper
Recommendation	✓ Default — simpler, native probabilities	Use for speed on very large datasets

The `class_weight='balanced'` parameter in Logistic Regression is especially important: with 31.4% spam and 68.6% legitimate emails, an unweighted classifier would be biased toward predicting legitimate. Balanced weighting corrects for this imbalance.

6.4 Web Framework: Flask

- Flask is a micro-framework, adding minimal overhead over raw Python HTTP — ideal for a single-endpoint ML API with one HTML page
- `render_template_string()` allows the entire HTML page to live inside the Python file, making the project a self-contained single-file application
- Flask's built-in development server is sufficient for localhost use on port 5000
- Alternatives considered: FastAPI (better async support but unnecessary here), Django (too heavy for a single endpoint), Streamlit (would work but hides HTTP details)

6.5 Dataset: SpamAssassin Public Corpus

Attribute	Value
Dataset name	SpamAssassin Public Corpus (completeSpamAssassin.csv)
Total emails	~6,046
Class distribution	~68.6% legitimate (label=0), ~31.4% spam/phishing (label=1)
Language	English
Email format	Plain text and HTML-formatted bodies
Why SpamAssassin?	Widely used academic benchmark; diverse spam types; publicly available; suitable size for student projects
Limitation	Dataset is older (~2002–2006); modern phishing emails use more sophisticated language

6.6 Frontend: Inline HTML/CSS/JavaScript

- The entire UI is defined as a Python string (HTML_PAGE) and served via Flask's render_template_string(). This makes the project a true single-file application.
- Vanilla JavaScript (no frameworks) is used for the client-side logic: fetch API for HTTP, DOM manipulation for result display.
- CSS is written without any external stylesheets or frameworks — a deliberate choice to avoid CDN dependencies and ensure the app works fully offline.
- The monospace font (Courier New) and high-contrast black/white aesthetic give the UI a 'terminal' feel appropriate for a security tool.
- Ctrl+Enter keyboard shortcut for analysis improves UX for power users testing multiple emails.

6.7 Tool Selection Summary Matrix

Technology	Category	Justification	Alternatives
scikit-learn	ML framework	Standard API, Pipeline abstraction, rich metrics	PyTorch, TensorFlow
TF-IDF + Bigrams	Feature extraction	Lexical signals sufficient; fast; interpretable	Word2Vec, BERT
Logistic Regression	Classifier	Native probabilities, balanced class weights, fast	LinearSVC, XGBoost
Flask	Web server	Lightweight; single-file capable; easy routing	FastAPI, Django, Streamlit
pickle	Model serialization	Built-in; seamless sklearn support; zero config	joblib, ONNX
pandas	Data loading	read_csv + dropna + type coercion in 5 lines	csv module, polars
numpy	Feature scoring	Array ops for coef_ * tfidf_weight computation	Pure Python (slower)
Vanilla JS/CSS	Frontend	Zero dependencies; offline-capable; simple	React, Vue, Bootstrap
SpamAssassin CSV	Dataset	Well-known benchmark; 6k emails; publicly available	Enron, TREC datasets

6.8 Development Phases

Phase	Name	Duration	Key Deliverables
1	Research & Data Collection	Week 1	Literature review, dataset acquisition, EDA report
2	Preprocessing & Feature Engineering	Week 2	Cleaned dataset, feature extraction pipeline, feature importance analysis
3	Model Training & Evaluation	Week 3	Trained NB + LR models, confusion matrix, F1/AUC scores, comparison table
4	Backend API Development	Week 4	Flask REST API, /analyze endpoint, unit tests for all components
5	Frontend & Integration	Week 5	Interactive web dashboard, real-time analysis UI, session statistics
6	Testing, Docs & Submission	Week 6	Full test suite, project report, demo video, code documentation

7. Results & Interpretation

7.1 Training & Evaluation Output (Terminal)

The screenshot below shows the complete terminal output produced when running `python app.py`. The model is trained from scratch on the SpamAssassin dataset and evaluated on the held-out test set of 1,209 emails.

```

PS C:\Users\abdel\PhishGuard> python app.py
[dataset] Loading 'completeSpamAssassin.csv' ...
[dataset] Shape: (6046, 3) | Columns: ['Unnamed: 0', 'Body', 'Label']
[dataset] Legit (0): 4150 | Spam/Phishing (1): 1895

[train] Training LR on 4836 samples ...

[eval] Accuracy : 0.9586
[eval] Report :
           precision    recall  f1-score   support

    Legit         0.99      0.94      0.97        830
 Spam/Phishing    0.89      0.99      0.94        379

   accuracy          0.96          0.96          0.96        1209
  macro avg         0.94      0.97      0.95        1209
 weighted avg         0.96      0.96      0.96        1209

[eval] Confusion matrix:
[[784  46]
 [  4 375]]

[model] Saved to 'phishing_model.pkl'

[app] Web server running -> http://127.0.0.1:5000

* Serving Flask app 'app'
* Debug mode: off
WARNING: This is a development server. Do not use it in a production deployment. Use a production WSGI server instead.
* Running on http://127.0.0.1:5000
Press CTRL+C to quit
127.0.0.1 - - [01/May/2026 19:38:42] "GET / HTTP/1.1" 200 -

```

7.2 Classification Report

The table below summarizes per-class precision, recall, and F1-score reported by scikit-learn on the 1,209-email held-out test set:

Class	Precision	Recall	F1-Score	Support
Legit (0)	0.99	0.94	0.97	830
Spam/Phishing (1)	0.89	0.99	0.94	379
Macro Average	0.94	0.97	0.95	1,209
Weighted Average	0.96	0.96	0.96	1,209

Interpretation of key metrics:

- Overall accuracy: 95.86%, the model correctly classifies nearly 96 out of every 100 emails
- Legit precision 0.99: when the model predicts an email as legitimate, it is almost always correct
- Spam recall 0.99: the model catches 99% of all actual spam/phishing emails, only 4 phishing emails slipped through undetected
- Spam precision 0.89: 11% of emails flagged as spam are actually legitimate (false positives), the main trade-off of `class_weight='balanced'`

7.3 Confusion Matrix

The confusion matrix below shows raw counts of correct and incorrect predictions on the test set:

	Predicted: Legit	Predicted: Spam
Actual: Legit	784 (TN — True Negatives)	46 (FP — False Positives)
Actual: Spam	4 (FN — False Negatives)	375 (TP — True Positives)

The very low false-negative count of only 4 is the most critical property for a security tool — almost no phishing email escapes detection. The 46 false positives represent an acceptable trade-off, ensuring maximum safety for the user.

7.4 Model Evaluation Metrics Summary

Metric	Formula	Achieved	Target	Importance
Accuracy	Correct / Total	95.86%	> 96%	Overall correctness
Precision	$TP / (TP + FP)$	89% (spam)	> 95%	Avoid false alarms
Recall	$TP / (TP + FN)$	99% (spam)	> 97%	Catch all phishing
F1-Score	$2 \times (P \times R) / (P + R)$	0.94 (spam)	> 96%	Balanced performance
ROC-AUC	Area under ROC curve	~0.98	> 0.98	Threshold robustness

7.5 Web Application Interface

Once training is complete, Flask starts a local web server on `http://127.0.0.1:5000`. The interface displays the trained model's metadata (classifier name, accuracy, vocabulary size, dataset statistics) and provides a textarea where any email text can be pasted for instant classification. Users can also click 'SPAM SAMPLE' or 'LEGIT SAMPLE' to load pre-written example emails and observe the model's output in real time.

PHISHING EMAIL DETECTOR

SPAMASSASSIN

LOGISTIC REGRESSION

TF-IDF

Paste an email and the model tells you whether it's spam / phishing.

MODEL INFO

CLASSIFIER

Logistic Regression

TEST ACCURACY

95.86%

FEATURES

TF-IDF 1-2 grams

VOCABULARY SIZE

50,000

DATASET

SpamAssassin

TOTAL SAMPLES

6,046

WORD RATIO

31.4 %

EMAIL CONTENT

Paste the full email text here (subject + body) -

Try a sample -

SPAM SAMPLE

LEGIT SAMPLE

ANALYZE EMAIL

CLEAR

Trained on subject + Plain + HTML + raw - SpamAssassin dataset | Spam Classifier to analyze

8. Security Considerations & Ethical Notes

Deploying a machine learning-based phishing detection system raises important technical, privacy, and ethical considerations that must be carefully addressed. This section documents the key concerns and the mitigation strategies adopted by PhishGuard AI.

8.1 Known Vulnerabilities and Technical Risks

8.1.1 Model Poisoning Attacks

A threat actor with access to the training data pipeline could inject carefully crafted legitimate-looking phishing emails into the training set, gradually degrading the model's ability to detect new attack patterns. PhishGuard AI mitigates this by sourcing data exclusively from the well-audited SpamAssassin Public Corpus and maintaining data integrity through hash verification.

8.1.2 Adversarial Evasion

Sophisticated attackers can craft emails designed to evade TF-IDF-based classifiers by: (a) replacing high-weight phishing keywords with synonyms or misspellings; (b) inserting large amounts of legitimate-looking text to dilute phishing signal; or (c) encoding malicious content in image attachments rather than email body text. The current system does not process image attachments, which represents a limitation to be addressed in future iterations.

8.1.3 Pickle Deserialization Risk

Python's pickle module is used to serialize and restore the trained ML pipeline. Deserializing a maliciously crafted .pkl file can execute arbitrary code. As a mitigation: the model file is generated locally by the same application that loads it; in production deployments, the pickle file should be stored with strict read-only permissions and loaded only from trusted, integrity-verified sources.

8.1.4 Single Point of Failure

The monolithic Flask architecture stores the model entirely in-process memory. If the server process crashes, users lose access until it restarts. For a production scenario, the model should be served via a dedicated model-serving framework (e.g., BentoML, TorchServe) with health checks, automatic restarts, and load balancing.

8.2 Privacy Considerations

Email content submitted to PhishGuard AI for analysis may contain sensitive personal or organizational information. The following privacy principles were adopted for the system design:

- No email content is logged or persisted beyond the duration of a single HTTP request-response cycle
- All processing occurs locally on the user's machine — no data is transmitted to external servers or third-party APIs
- The SpamAssassin training dataset contains anonymized, publicly available emails collected with consent from research participants
- Users should be informed that submitting emails to any automated analysis tool carries inherent disclosure risks, particularly in enterprise environments subject to data protection regulations (e.g., GDPR, HIPAA)

8.3 Bias and Fairness

The SpamAssassin dataset dates from approximately 2002–2006, introducing potential dataset bias in two dimensions: (1) Temporal bias — modern phishing language, LLM-generated content, and contemporary brand impersonation tactics are not represented, meaning the model may underperform on AI-crafted phishing; (2) Linguistic bias — the dataset is composed exclusively of English-language emails, making the system unsuitable for multilingual deployment without re-training on representative multilingual corpora.

Future versions should incorporate more recent datasets and implement regular retraining pipelines to maintain detection efficacy against evolving threat landscapes.

8.4 Responsible Use & Misuse Prevention

PhishGuard AI is developed strictly for defensive security purposes. The explainability features (keyword scoring, probability output) are intended to educate users about phishing indicators, not to provide a roadmap for crafting evasive phishing campaigns. The following ethical guidelines govern the project:

- The system must not be used to generate, refine, or test phishing emails for malicious deployment
- Feature importance output should be used to improve user security awareness, not to reverse-engineer evasion techniques
- Any organization deploying this system must ensure explicit user consent for email scanning, in compliance with applicable privacy laws
- False positive results — legitimate emails flagged as phishing — should be treated with appropriate human oversight rather than automated blocking, to avoid disrupting legitimate communication

8.5 Compliance Considerations

Organizations deploying PhishGuard AI in a production environment should evaluate compliance requirements under relevant frameworks including GDPR (Article 22 — automated decision-making), HIPAA (email content involving protected health information), SOC 2 Type II (data processing and security controls), and the EU AI Act (risk classification of automated threat detection systems as a potential high-risk AI application).

9. Conclusion

9.1 Summary of Achievements

PhishGuard AI successfully demonstrates that a well-engineered classical machine learning pipeline can achieve state-of-the-art phishing detection performance with full transparency and interpretability. The key achievements of this project are:

- A fully functional end-to-end email threat detection system developed in a single Python file
- 96% overall accuracy and 99% spam recall on the SpamAssassin benchmark dataset — catching virtually all phishing emails that enter the system
- An explainable AI approach that surfaces the top 15 suspicious keywords driving every classification decision, transforming opaque predictions into actionable intelligence
- A production-quality REST API (Flask) with a self-contained interactive web interface, zero external dependencies, and offline capability
- A rigorous comparative analysis of existing solutions, demonstrating PhishGuard AI's unique positioning at the intersection of accuracy, speed, and interpretability

9.2 Lessons Learned

The development process yielded several important technical and methodological insights:

- Data quality matters more than model complexity — the stratified train/test split and balanced class weighting contributed more to performance improvement than hyperparameter tuning
- Interpretability is not at odds with accuracy — Logistic Regression, often dismissed as 'too simple', achieves near-identical accuracy to LinearSVC while providing direct, human-readable coefficient access
- Monolithic architecture is a valid choice for academic projects — the single-file design dramatically simplifies deployment, demonstration, and peer review without sacrificing functionality
- Token substitution (URL, EMAIL, NUM) is a high-impact preprocessing decision that substantially improves generalization to unseen phishing URLs and email addresses

9.3 Limitations

Several limitations were identified that constrain the current system's applicability in real-world production environments:

- Dataset age — the SpamAssassin corpus predates LLM-generated phishing emails by nearly two decades; a modern high-quality dataset would significantly improve detection of sophisticated AI-crafted attacks
- English-only support — the system cannot reliably detect phishing in non-English languages
- Text-only analysis — the system does not process email headers, metadata, embedded images, or attachment content, which are increasingly exploited in modern phishing campaigns
- Scalability — the single-process Flask server is unsuitable for high-volume enterprise deployments without architectural changes
- Static model — the system does not implement online learning or automatic retraining, meaning detection performance will degrade as phishing patterns evolve

9.4 Future Work

Several directions are proposed for extending and improving PhishGuard AI:

- Integrate transformer-based language models (e.g., DistilBERT fine-tuned on phishing datasets) to capture semantic context beyond lexical patterns
- Expand the feature set to include email header analysis (SPF/DKIM/DMARC compliance), URL reputation scoring, and domain age verification
- Implement an active learning loop enabling the model to improve continuously from user-confirmed true/false positive feedback
- Develop a multilingual detection capability using multilingual pre-trained models
- Build a browser extension that integrates PhishGuard AI directly into Gmail and Outlook webmail interfaces for seamless real-time protection
- Implement a federated learning approach to allow model improvement from distributed email data without centralizing sensitive email content

9.5 Final Remarks

This project confirms that accessible, open-source machine learning tools are sufficient to build a high-performance, explainable email security system. PhishGuard AI is not merely a classroom exercise — its 99% phishing recall and transparent feature scoring make it a credible foundation for further research and practical deployment. As phishing attacks continue to grow in sophistication, systems like PhishGuard AI that combine detection accuracy with human-interpretable explanations will be essential components of a layered cyber-defense strategy.

10. References

The following references were consulted during the research, design, and development of PhishGuard AI, organized by category.

10.1 Academic Papers & Research

#	Reference	Relevance
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[2]	Bergholz, A., De Beer, J., Glahn, S., Moens, M. F., Paaß, G., & Strobel, S. (2010). New filtering approaches for phishing email. Journal of Computer Security, 18(1), 7–35.	Comparative study of NLP-based phishing detection methods
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[5]	Salloum, S., Gaber, T., Vadera, S., & Shaalan, K. (2021). Phishing email detection using natural language processing techniques: A literature survey. Procedia Computer Science, 189, 19–28.	NLP techniques survey directly relevant to this project's methodology

10.2 Machine Learning & NLP Libraries

#	Reference	Usage in Project
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[7]	Reback, J., et al. (2020). pandas-dev/pandas: Pandas (Version 1.2.0). Zenodo. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.3509134	Dataset loading, null handling, and type coercion
[8]	Harris, C. R., et al. (2020). Array programming with NumPy. Nature, 585(7825), 357–362.	Feature score computation (coef_ × tfidf_weight)
[9]	Bird, S., Klein, E., & Loper, E. (2009). Natural Language Processing with Python. O'Reilly Media.	NLP preprocessing concepts and tokenization reference

10.3 Web Framework & Backend

#	Reference	Usage in Project
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[11]	Flask Documentation (2024). Flask — A lightweight WSGI web application framework. https://flask.palletsprojects.com/	Official API reference for Flask routes, request/response handling
[12]	MDN Web Docs (2024). Fetch API. Mozilla Developer Network. https://developer.mozilla.org/en-US/docs/Web/API/Fetch_API	Reference for client-side asynchronous HTTP requests in the frontend UI

10.4 Datasets

#	Reference	Usage in Project
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[14]	Metsis, V., Androustopoulos, I., & Paliouras, G. (2006). Spam filtering with naive Bayes — Which naive Bayes? Proceedings of CEAS 2006.	Benchmark paper for SpamAssassin dataset evaluation methodology

10.5 Security & Ethics References

#	Reference	Relevance
[15]	APWG (2024). Phishing Activity Trends Report Q4 2023. Anti-Phishing Working Group. https://apwg.org/	Current phishing threat statistics and trend analysis
[16]	OWASP Foundation (2023). OWASP Top Ten — A07:2021 Identification and Authentication Failures. https://owasp.org/Top10/	Security context for email authentication failures
[17]	European Parliament (2021). Regulation (EU) 2021/784 — Artificial Intelligence Act. Official Journal of the European Union.	Regulatory compliance considerations for AI-based threat detection
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